Krishnamurthy went to the nearest phone booth and alerted Malligai that Nalini and Murugan could be on their way back to Madras.

Malligai transformed into a war room.

A large map of Madras was laid out on the table at the centre, illuminated by a bright overhead lamp. A strategic meeting on how to catch the couple alive started with Kaarthikeyan, Raju, Kanth, Verma, Captain Ravindran of the NSG, Sri Kumar, Ragothaman and DIG Manoharan (of Tamil Nadu Police) in attendance. All they knew was Nalini and Murugan could be coming to Madras in a bus. The questions far outnumbered the answers. What if the duo switched to a train or a taxi?

Kaarthikeyan asked Manoharan what the possible alighting points on the Villupuram-to-Madras route were. Drawing their attention to the map, Manoharan said the first stop upon entry in Madras was Tambaram, by the city border. The bus picking up passengers from Villupuram originated from Madurai and terminated at the Saidapet bus terminus. Kanth's instant counter was, 'What if she gets off before the terminus? Somewhere in the middle of the city?'

'Villivakkam is further up north, sir. If that's where they're headed, they'll have to get off at Saidapet,' said Ragothaman. Kanth's next question was if that was close to West Mambalam, where Nalini and Murugan might have another possible hideout.

Kaarthikeyan, putting a bright red tack on the map marking Saidapet, said it was a distance of 18–20 km; he marked two more points on the map between Tambaram and Saidapet. Everyone appeared tense. Manoharan looked at the map again.

'We can deploy men at the bus stops that have wide, crowded terminals. It'll be easier to blend in with the crowd there. Apart from Tambaram, teams can be stationed at the Chromepet bus stand and at Alandur, before Saidapet,' he pointed out, adding one more point with a red felt pen.

His face showing intense concentration, Kaarthikeyan told Manoharan to deploy his teams to keep a strict watch on railway stations and taxi stands close to those points as well. Raju took another look at the map with the four bright red points— Tambaram, Chromepet, Alandur and Saidapet—and